

Datacenter water usage is NOT an AI issue.

Posted by u/iitbfrfr • 0 points • 23 comments

It would be ignorant to say that AI datacenters don't have environmental effects. They do. But that is not AI(the technology)'s fault.

It's capitalism and bad management. Some nations force the construction of datacenters, even if freshwater supply in that location is scarce.

"Since 2022, more than two-thirds of new data centers have been built in water-stressed areas, including Texas, Arizona, Saudi Arabia, and India, where freshwater scarcity is already a critical issue." - Wikipedia

"In regions like Aragon, Spain, Amazon's planned data centers are licensed to withdraw 755,720 cubic metres (612.67 acre·ft) of water per year, sparking conflicts with farmers who rely on the same dwindling supplies." - Wikipedia

If the same datacenters were to be setup in a location where it wouldn't stress the local populace, it wouldn't be an issue. But, due to mismanagement, and capitalist mindset of prioritising profits, these datacenters are allowed to be made.

AI as a technology is not bad, if managed well. We as a species cannot be expected to halt technological progress, but what we can do is limit damage. Which isn't happening. And this should be our biggest focus, not pointless hatred on AI.

Comments

u/Difficult_Limit2718 • 1 points • 2026-02-01 21:48 UTC

You think it's bad now, the morons at ASHRAE are trying to codify using water... It's debatable if it's better to use water or electricity for cooling, but dictating one of the other is stupid

u/IndigoFenix • 1 points • 2026-01-29 22:09 UTC

It's not just bad management - deserts happen to be really good places for building datacenters. Minimal humidity is great for computers, the land is cheaper, and there's a strong push to have them running on green energy sources, so reliable solar power is also a big plus.

The downside, of course, is that deserts are hot and water is scarce, so any nearby cities wind up competing with them for it.

u/Cute-Parfait6237 • 1 points • 2026-01-29 13:07 UTC

Wait, wouldn't proper management be bad for the AI users?

Since I'm assuming that the data centers are being quickly built to handle AI requests/improvements, regardless of the environmental impact it has on people nearby. But if they were to consider the impact, then surely that means that less data centers would've been built or would've exist at the moment

u/FlightFit335 • 2 points • 2026-01-29 11:13 UTC

This is a nothing burger. 200 million gallons of water per year.

Chicago pulls 750 million gallons per day from Lake Michigan. Per Day!

1 Avocado takes 50 gallons to grow. How many are thrown away?

u/Sad-Ad-8226 • 2 points • 2026-01-29 09:41 UTC

The same people that have no problem eating meat are complaining about water....

u/Human_certified • 2 points • 2026-01-29 09:28 UTC

These locations are generally places where locals either don't (Texas) or can't (Saudi Arabia) complain and file lawsuits, where there's no two-year environmental study needed, etc.

Apparently the cost of additional cooling is worth not having the hassle.

u/Regular-Turnover-212 • 1 points • 2026-01-29 08:50 UTC

I mean sure. But there are other issues with AI as well and they aren't all caused by capitalism.